DRUGS · LOCAL ANAESTHETICS AND VASOCONSTRICTORS

Benzydamine and mucosal analgesics

Sore throats, aphthous ulcers, post-tonsillectomy pain and radiotherapy mucositis all hurt where tablets cannot reach well. Benzydamine is an anti-inflammatory and mildly anaesthetic mouthwash and spray; lidocaine gels and viscous solutions numb ulcers; and barrier products coat raw mucosa. They are adjuncts to systemic analgesia, not replacements for it.

1 CHAPTER ONE At a glance

The agents on one page.

1.1 Summary

BENZYDAMINE AND MUCOSAL ANALGESICS

	SUMMARY
Agents	Benzydamine 0.15% mouthwash and spray; lidocaine gels and 2% viscous solution; choline salicylate gel (not under 16 years); barrier gels (polyvinylpyrrolidone and hyaluronic acid products); doxepin rinse (specialist)
How they work	Benzydamine: local NSAID-like inhibition of inflammatory mediators and mild anaesthesia; lidocaine: sodium-channel block; barrier gels: coat and protect
ENT uses	Painful pharyngitis and tonsillitis; aphthous ulcers; pain after tonsillectomy (adjunct); oral mucositis during head and neck radiotherapy (benzydamine is recommended for prevention in moderate-dose radiotherapy by MASCC guidelines)
Benzydamine dose	Mouthwash 15 ml rinsed or gargled every 1.5 to 3 hours (dilute with water if it stings); spray 4 to 8 sprays every 1.5 to 3 hours
Avoid	Viscous lidocaine in young children and patients with impaired swallowing (aspiration, choking, toxicity); choline salicylate in children (Reye syndrome)

2 CHAPTER TWO Using them in ENT

Practice.

2.1 Radiotherapy mucositis

Mouth care during head and neck radiotherapy includes regular saline or bicarbonate rinses, good oral hygiene, benzydamine from the start of treatment, systemic analgesia escalating to opioids, nutritional support (often a feeding tube), and treatment of candidal infection.

2.2 After tonsillectomy

Regular oral analgesia matters most; benzydamine sprays may help before meals.

3 CHAPTER THREE Safety

What goes wrong.

3.1 Adverse effects

Stinging, numbness and taste disturbance with benzydamine; lidocaine toxicity and aspiration when the throat is numbed; salicylate toxicity with large amounts of choline salicylate.

4 CHAPTER FOUR For the examination

What the examiner wants to hear.

4.1 Viva essentials

WHAT THE EXAMINER IS LOOKING FOR

- Prevention and treatment of **radiation mucositis**.
- Risks of viscous lidocaine.

4.2 Common pitfalls

COMMON PITFALLS

- Recommending viscous lidocaine to a young child.

Written for this app from BNF and BNF for Children; NICE and specialist society guidance; Scott-Brown; Cummings. Figures reproduced from the books for private study. Study reference only: follow local protocols and senior advice for patients.